



Divorced from reality: A complete separation of religion from the state is impossible

no. What your marriage means, how you will inherit property, how your children will be assigned guardians—all of this is determined by laws governing the religious community into which you were accidentally born. These laws are administered by the state.

In modern democracies, religious communities are political units because numbers are crucial in order to have access to power. Why, otherwise, would it matter if tribal people convert to Christianity? Or Dalits to Buddhism? Because it is an act of secession, a blatantly political move. It is a deliberate exit from one community into another. It is misleading to think of "religion" as a private business between you and your God(s). If it were, a woman walking into the Sabarimala shrine would not shake the foundations of Hinduism. Private beliefs are private, but "religion" is not private. If you do have private religious beliefs, they have nothing to do with your religious identity, which is public.

One way to escape this inexorable gaze of the state would be to slide under its radar. If more and more people chose to exit the communities of their birth, and evaded state regulation of their private lives, there would be spaces of relative freedom. The implications of living like that are huge, but it's worth thinking about.

The author is a professor in political thought at the School of International Studies, JNU



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